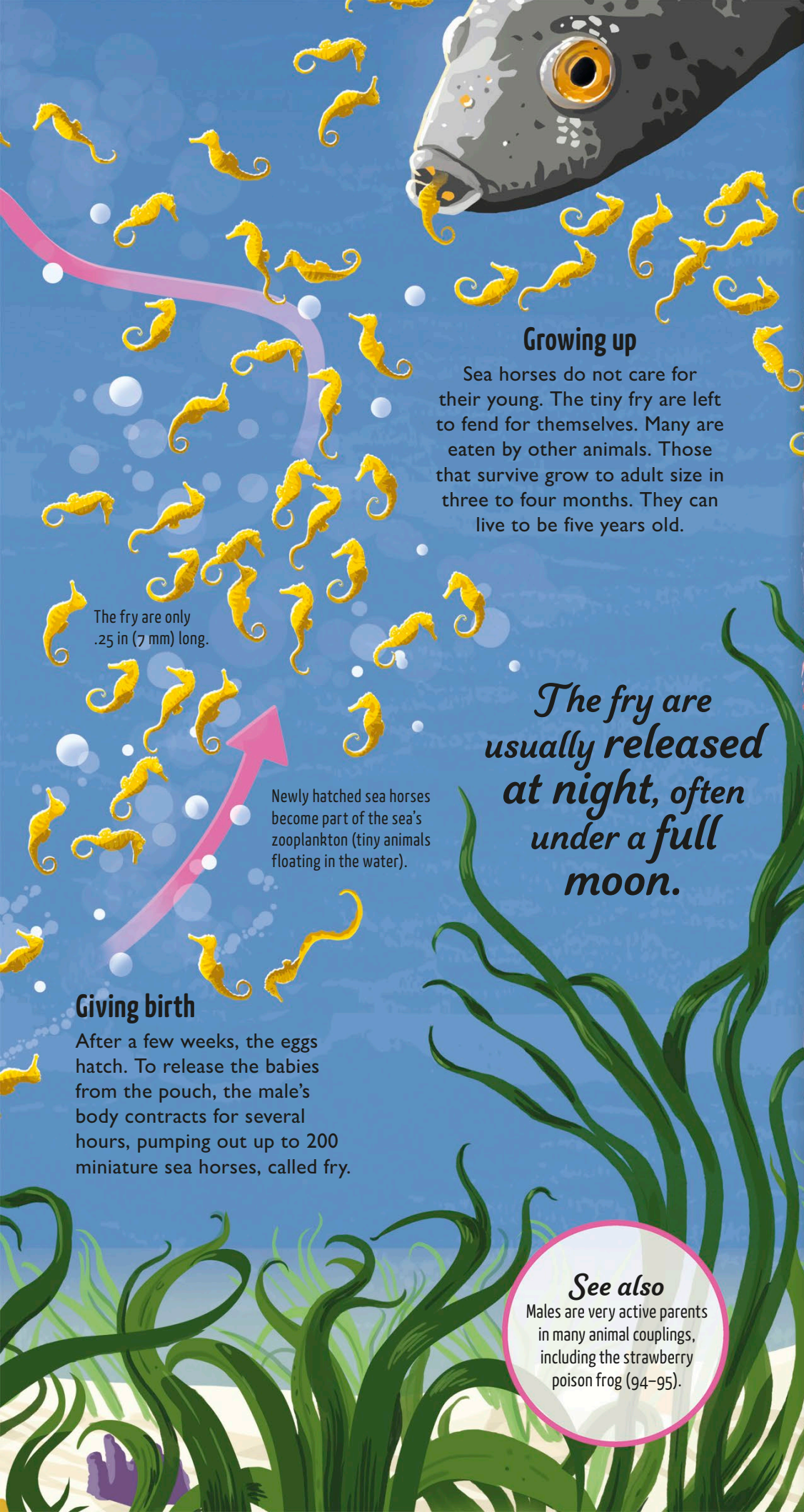




The fry are only .25 in (7 mm) long.

Newly hatched sea horses become part of the sea's zooplankton (tiny animals floating in the water).

Giving birth

After a few weeks, the eggs hatch. To release the babies from the pouch, the male's body contracts for several hours, pumping out up to 200 miniature sea horses, called fry.

Growing up

Sea horses do not care for their young. The tiny fry are left to fend for themselves. Many are eaten by other animals. Those that survive grow to adult size in three to four months. They can live to be five years old.

The fry are usually released at night, often under a full moon.

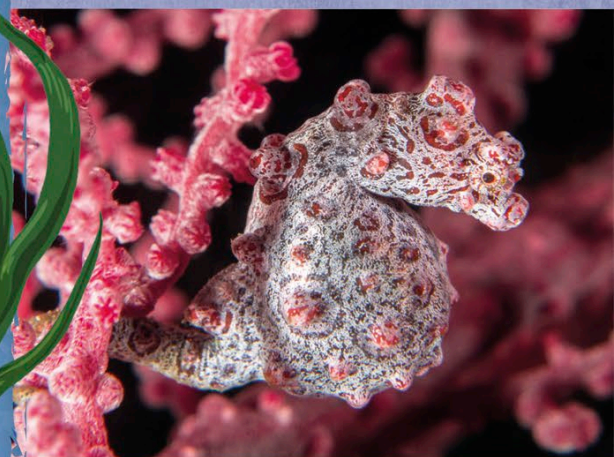
See also

Males are very active parents in many animal couplings, including the strawberry poison frog (94–95).

Big-belly sea horse Found in Australia, this is one of the largest of all sea horses. As its name suggests, it has what looks like a pot belly.



Pygmy sea horse The pygmy sea horse is great at camouflage. Its pink color matches its coral home.



Gold specs jawfish Male jawfish also give birth to live young. It incubates the eggs in its mouth for 8–10 days and pumps them out as they hatch.

